

Pagan and the Lost Touch

A Well-Shaped Musical

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PLOT SUMMARY

A decade after she began student teaching, Ms. Ngo is retiring. Pegi, her former student, unveils Ms. Ngo's dark history and gets to the bottom of this (dimension).

Pegi starts her first day in kindergarten at Hooper Elementary, unable to fit in any of their classmates' circles ("This Peg Fits Nowhere"). Today is also Ms. Ngo's first day as a student teacher, assisting Ms. Taft. Ms. Ngo pairs Pegi up with Amby. They become instant friends as they both are the oldest children of their working-class families.

Ms. Ngo has a lively persona compared to her mature counterpart. However, she washes away any shape the kids chalk up and dissuades anyone from playing hopscotch. She even locks away Pegi's supernatural rock ("Don't Play Games"). Pegi discovered this rock on the riverbed they almost drowned in.

Over a decade later, Ms. Ngo announces a sudden retirement. Her outlook on public education deteriorated throughout the years as technology replaced its spirited nature. She just does not feel as needed anymore. The elementary school hosts a party for her. Much of her former students have remained creative ("Destined for Greatness"). Pegi and Amby volunteer to set up the party, so that Pegi can sneak out with their rock. Pegi accomplishes that, sneaking the suitcase containing their rock out.

But while walking out of the school, Pegi decides to hopscotch and falls into another dimension ("Hop the Block").

In another dimension, Pegi finds Ms. Ngo_u fidgeting around with toy blocks. Ms. Ngo_u is a much more mature Ms. Ngo. Ms. Ngo_u explains that the real-world Ms. Ngo trapped her here. Ms. Ngo_u convinces Pegi that she is the real Ms. Ngo ("Misnomer"). Pegi frees Ms. Ngo_u.

Ms. Ngo_u visits Ms. Ngo. They quarrel until Ms. Ngo_u knocks out Ms. Ngo onto the chalked-up ground. They toss the rock on by Ms. Ngo, leading her to dissolve into the mirror dimension. Ms. Ngo_u gets out of retirement and goes on a rampage upon the school system, undermining its spirited nature ("The Common Man").

In the real world, Amby shares news that Ms. Ngo_u changed their mind about retirement. However, Amby finds Pegi_u is unlike Pegi. Pegi_u is suddenly distant.

Pegi treks around the mirror dimension, seeing inner children wander about, living the dream they want to live. Each spirit

remembers the moment their inner adult dragged them into this mirror dimension ("Are You a Hugger?"). Ms. Ngo's adult spirit is actually Ms. Ngo_μ. Pegi realizes they unleashed a monster upon the real world. The Ms. Ngo everyone knows is truly the real one. She has fought to keep everyone's inner child. Pegi tries to leave but realizes Ms. Ngo_μ took their rock ("Lost Touch").

In the next act, we revisit Ms. Ngo's backstory when she was a kid. Her Buddhist family made her meditate when she gets out of line. She would do so in a chalked-up shape. Ms. Ngo_μ would haunt her every so often due to this, but Ms. Ngo always fought back adulthood. Ms. Ngo_μ's last visit was when Ms. Ngo first started student teaching. Pegi unknowingly helped Ms. Ngo trap Ms. Ngo_μ for good ("Sitting in a Circle").

Time passes a decade since the present. In adulthood, Pegi_μ and Amby are no longer friends. Pegi_μ fits in as a pragmatic adult in society while Amby still has their childhood spirit. Ms. Ngo_μ is now the ruthless superintendent of the school district ("Welcome to the Real World").

Pegi notices Ms. Ngo is around the mirror dimension and returned to teaching. They join their class. Ms. Ngo is living her best life as a compassionate teacher once again. Ms. Ngo explains that no one's inner child truly dies but goes to live where they are ("Believe in a World That Does Not Need You").

Pegi notices that Amby's inner child has not come around, leaving them content about losing touch with reality ("Lost Touch with Reality"). Pegi now fits in, getting to be the child they needed to be ("This Peg Fits").

Pagan and the Lost Touch frames the loss of our inner child within the interpersonal themes of division, mentor-student relationship, and the passage of time along with acceptance. The story asks the question that many compassionate teachers have: Should we believe in a world that thinks it does not need you?

CAST OF CHARACTERS

PEGI, kid-teenager-adult, someone whose pre-K teacher did not allow them to play hopscotch

MS. MI-SUN NGO (no), adult, a teacher who is too good for the real world

PEGI_p, adult, byproduct of Pegi's entering the mirror dimension

MS. MI-SUN NGO_p (no mu), adult, mirror dimension's Ms. Ngo

AMBY, adult, mirror dimension's Ms. Ngo

MS. TAFT, adult, Ms. Ngo's superior

MUSICAL NUMBERS

Act I

1. "This Peg Fits Nowhere"
2. "Don't Play Games"
3. "Destined for Greatness"
4. "Hop the Block"
5. "Misnomer"
6. "The Common Man"
7. "Are You a Hugger?"
8. "Lost Touch"

Act II

9. "Sitting in a Circle"
10. "Welcome to the Real World"
11. "Believe in a World That Does Not Need You"
12. "Lost Touch with Reality"
13. "This Peg Fits"